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Marcos Jr looks ahead to CEPA deal with UAE

MANILA
BY JAY HILOTIN
Senior Assistant Editor

President Ferdinand Marcos Jr of the Philippines has told *Gulf News* in an exclusive interview ahead of his visit to the UAE that his country, currently the world's 30th-biggest economy, has plenty of room to grow.

He cited recent key reforms: the unlocking of 99-year land leases to attract long-term investors, reduced income tax rates/duties, and the updated Public-Private Partnership law, among others, enabling the country to snag multi-billion investments in key industries.

The Philippine leader, 68, aims to do more. More importantly, he highlighted the benefits of the upcoming Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) between the UAE and the Philippines, Manila's first such agreement with a Middle East nation.

Bright future

"Indeed, the future of the Philippines is bright. We will continue to work tirelessly to bring in investments, create jobs, and uplift the lives of our people," the President stated.

Today, Marcos Jr is expected to witness the signing of the CEPA in Abu Dhabi. The Philippine leader previously visited the UAE in 2024, marking 50 years of diplomatic relations between the two countries.

SEE ALSO P5

Iran organises mass rallies as Trump weighs 'strong options'

EU PARLIAMENT BANS IRANIAN DIPLOMATS, REPRESENTATIVES FROM PREMISES

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Iranian authorities yesterday sought to regain control of the streets with mass pro-government rallies after US President Donald Trump said Washington was considering "very strong options" in response to a crackdown on nationwide protests that activists say has killed hundreds of civilians.

The unrest, now entering its third week, was initially sparked by economic grievances but has grown into one of the most serious challenges to Iran's ruling system since the 1979 Islamic revolution.

Trump said that his administration was reviewing a range of responses after reports that protesters had been killed by Iranian security forces.

"They're starting to, it looks like, and there seem to be some people killed that aren't supposed to be killed," Trump told reporters. "These are violent — if you call them leaders. I don't know if they're leaders or just they rule through violence."

Cyberattacks, military strikes

According to two people familiar with internal White House discussions, Trump and his national security team are weighing options that include cyberattacks and direct military strikes by the United States or Israel.

"The military is looking at it, and we're looking at some very strong options," Trump said later. Asked about Iran's threats of retaliation, he added: "If they do that, we will hit them at levels



AFF

■ The courtyard of the Forensic Diagnostic and Laboratory Centre of Tehran Province in Kahrizak is seen with dozens of bodies in body bags laid out for family members.

that they've never been hit before."

Iranian officials warned that US forces and Israel would be considered "legitimate targets" if Washington intervenes militarily. Earlier yesterday, Foreign Min-

ister Abbas Araghchi said Iran was prepared for both conflict and negotiations.

"The Islamic Republic of Iran is not seeking war, but is fully prepared for war," Araghchi told a gathering of foreign ambassa-

●● They're starting to, it looks like, and there seem to be some people killed that aren't supposed to be killed. These are violent — if you call them leaders. I don't know if they're leaders or just they rule through violence."

Donald Trump
| US President

dors in Tehran, adding that Iran remained open to talks based on "mutual respect".

Authorities have imposed a sweeping internet blackout lasting more than 84 hours. The Human Rights Activists News Agency said it had confirmed at least 544 deaths, while warning the toll could rise further.

As international pressure mounted, the European Parliament announced it had banned all Iranian diplomats and representatives from its premises over the repression.

"It cannot be business as usual," European Parliament President Roberta Metsola said.

At home, the Iranian government organised rallies across the country yesterday to demonstrate support for the Islamic republic. Thousands gathered in Tehran's Enghelab (Revolution) Square, waving national flags as prayers were held for victims of what authorities have described as "riots", state television reported.

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UAE approves new drug for heart failure treatment

UAE second country to authorise dual-action tablet

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

The Emirates Drug Establishment (EDE) yesterday announced that it has authorised Inpefa® (sotagliflozin), a new drug for heart failure, making the UAE the second country worldwide to approve the therapy, in yet another step reflecting the UAE's leadership in adopting pharmaceutical innovations and strengthening its health care system.

Inpefa® (sotagliflozin) is the first dual SGLT1 and SGLT2 inhibitor approved for the treatment of heart failure. It is an oral medication that helps regulate blood glucose levels while supporting heart and kidney health.

Key medication

The treatment has been approved to reduce the risk of death from cardiovascular diseases, lower hospital admissions due to heart failure, and decrease urgent medi-

● **Inpefa® (sotagliflozin) is the first dual SGLT1 and SGLT2 inhibitor approved for the treatment of heart failure.**

cal visits associated with the condition among adults with heart failure, type 2 diabetes, chronic kidney disease, or other cardiovascular risk factors, EDE stated.

Heart failure is a chronic and serious medical condition that affects the heart's ability to pump blood efficiently, leading to advanced health complications and increased rates of hospitalisation. It represents a growing global health challenge.

EDE said studies have shown that Inpefa (sotagliflozin) can help individuals living with heart failure or those at risk of developing it by reducing complications and lowering the risk of serious cardiovascular problems. It has also been observed that patients who begin treatment during hospitalisation start to experience its therapeutic benefits at an early stage.



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